

Albatrosses and petrels

Order Procellariiformes

Atlantic yellow-nosed albatross

Thalassarche chlororhynchos

- ↔ 32 in (81 cm)
- 📍 South Atlantic Ocean
- ⊗ Endangered

One of the smallest of the southern albatrosses, this black-and-white species has a distinctive orange-tipped yellow ridge along the top

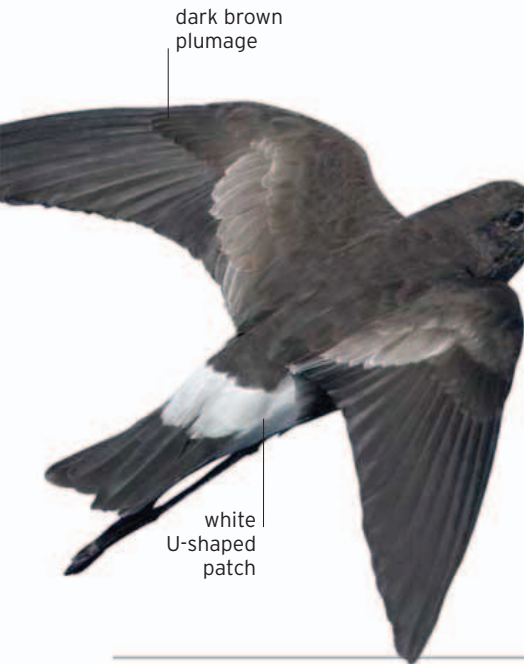
of its black bill. It lives in the South Atlantic, ranging widely over the ocean in search of fish, squid, and krill, as well as scraps scavenged from fishing fleets. In the breeding season, it nests in colonies on remote islands, each pair building a column-shaped nest of mud and vegetation for their single egg. Both parents rear the chick, which is able to fly within about four months.

Wilson's storm petrel

Oceanites oceanicus

- ↔ 7 in (18 cm)
- 📍 Pacific, Atlantic, Indian, and Southern oceans
- ⊗ Common

Only slightly bigger than a sparrow, this seabird has a vast distribution across the southern oceans, ranging north of the equator in the northern summer. Dark brown with a white patch on its rump, it flies over the ocean surface in search of small prey, often pattering on the water with its dangling feet. It nests in coastal colonies in Antarctica and nearby islands, in rock crevices and shallow burrows.



Northern fulmar

Fulmarus glacialis

- ↔ 18–20 in (45–50 cm)
- 📍 Arctic, North Pacific, North Atlantic oceans
- ⊗ Common



Although it looks like a gull, the northern fulmar is a petrel, more closely related to the albatrosses. It is a superb flier, soaring on updrafts near cliffs on stiff, straight wings. It hunts at sea for small fish, jellyfish, and squid, seizing most of its prey at the surface, but sometimes plunging into the water. It also follows fishing fleets to feast on discarded fish scraps. This habit has led to a rapid increase in its population.

Other species

- Wandering albatross
Diomedea exulans » pp366–67
- Waved albatross
Phoebastria irrorata » p125

Divers

Order Gaviiformes

Red-throated diver

Gavia stellata

- ↔ 22–28 in (55–70 cm)
- 📍 North America, Greenland, Europe, Asia
- ⊗ Common

In breeding plumage this sleek, elegant diving bird has a gray head set off by red eyes, vertical black and white stripes on the hindneck,

and a brick-red patch at the base of its thick, long neck. It is the smallest of the divers—birds so specialized for hunting fish underwater that they are almost helpless on land. It feeds at sea in winter, but nests by freshwater lakes and marshes in the far north, claiming its territory with loud wailing cries. The nests are usually a simple platform of reeds, rushes, and grass.

Grebes

Order Podicipediformes

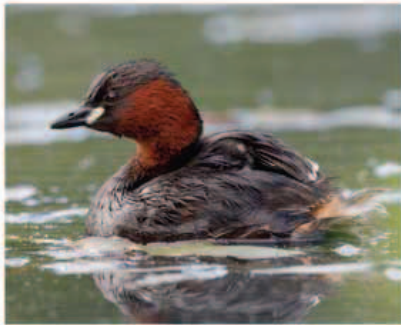
Little grebe

Tachybaptus ruficollis

- ↔ 10–12 in (25–30 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, Africa, Madagascar, New Guinea
- ⊗ Common

The plump, almost tailless grebe appears buoyant on the water, but is in fact a skilful diver, staying underwater for up to half a minute as it hunts for aquatic insects and similar freshwater prey. It stands and walks on land more easily than other grebes, and is also more

likely to fly outside of migration. Although wary and secretive, it often reveals its presence with a high-pitched trill during the summer breeding season.



Western grebe

Aechmophorus occidentalis

- ↔ 22–30 in (55–75 cm)
- 📍 C. and S. North America
- ⊗ Common

This is the largest North American grebe. It is black and white with a long, slim neck and a long, sharp yellow bill. It has a spectacular courtship display, during which the courting pair rear up out of the water and, holding themselves erect, run across the surface together for 66 ft (20 m) or more. They build their nest on the water, anchored to reeds. The parents take turns carrying the newly hatched young on their backs for the first two to four weeks.

Hoary-headed grebe

Poliocephalus poliocephalus

- ↔ 12 in (30 cm)
- 📍 Australia (including Tasmania), S. New Zealand
- ⊗ Common

This species is a specialized water bird; an expert diver, but clumsy on land. It breeds in large colonies, building floating nests of vegetation on the floodwaters that rise after heavy rain.

Other species

- Great crested grebe
Podiceps cristatus » p157
- Titicaca grebe
Rollandia microptera » p111